our closest living relatives. The study of these animals therefore offers us a unique chance to learn about ourselves and the origins of our behavior. Yet for many years the scientific community remained convinced that humankind was different from the rest of nature.

It was largely the work of British primatologist Jane Goodall that opened our eyes to the similarities between chimps and humans. In 1961, in an excited communication to her mentor, Louis Leakey, Goodall announced an observation that would shake the scientific establishment: she had seen a chimp using a tool. It was the first time this behavior had been documented and it would challenge perceived ideas of what it means to be human. (Tool use has since been observed in other animals, such as New Caledonian crows, octopuses, sea urchins, and dolphins.)

Goodall's knowledge of natural history had impressed Leakey on their first meeting in 1957 and he offered her a job studying the behavior of chimpanzees. As an anthropologist and paleontologist, Leakey believed in evolutionary theory, which proposed that humans and the great apes—chimpanzees, bonobos, gorillas, and orangutans—in the family Hominidae (Great Apes), share a common ancestor.